

Chapter 195 - Part 1

Extra 17-1

Another spring.

When Sheng Yan and Shen Xuan returned home for vacation, they found the house empty, with only the auntie responsible for cleaning. Both their mothers weren't home.

They separately called Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu, but no one answered.

The phones even showed they were powered off.

The two were already in university.

In high school they'd said they definitely wanted to be far apart when they went to university, but when it came time to fill in college preferences, Shen Xuan kept sneaking peeks at Sheng Yan's choices, again and again.

Sheng Yan even covered it up, "What are you doing?"

Shen Xuan: "Just looking."

"Did you forget you said there was no way you'd go to the same university as me?" Sheng Yan said.

Shen Xuan paused, then said righteously: "I'd like to, but I can't get in."

Sheng Yan: "..."

Intelligence was something you could trace from childhood.

Shen Xuan had been hyperactive since kindergarten, unable to muster any interest in studying.

But Sheng Yan was particularly smart.

The gap widened in high school.

The two were at the same high school, in the same class. Sheng Yan ranked first in the entire grade with a high score of 720, more than twenty points higher than second place, while Shen Xuan, as the younger twin sister, could only score two-thirds of her sister's score.

Her basic performance was over 400, and at best she could reach over 500.

Teachers often sighed looking at their nearly identical faces.

Shen Xuan could imagine what the teacher's internal monologue was—clearly their faces are almost the same, so how could their intelligence differ so much?

However, thanks to Sheng Yan, no matter how much Shen Xuan caused trouble and mischief in high school, teachers would turn a blind eye.

Same with the college entrance exam results.

Sheng Yan scored exactly two hundred points higher than Shen Xuan.

One got 720, one got 520.

Xu Qingzhu even teased her about it, "How did you manage to score exactly 520? If you'd scored a few points higher, you could say you were only over a hundred points behind your sister."

The gap would feel instantly smaller.

Shen Xuan had a flash of inspiration, raising both hands above her head to form a heart shape, "Because~ I love you~"

Everyone laughed together.

However, for Shen Xuan, over 500 points was plenty.

Because Shen Xuan had decided early on to take the arts track, majoring in performing arts.

520 points was enough for her to attend a top-tier domestic arts school.

Shen Xuan had to go through arts exams, so she'd selected her school early on—in the capital.

Sheng Yan would most likely stay in Haizhou City, probably applying to Qingyi University like Xu Qingzhu.

But Shen Xuan still held onto a tiny bit of hope in her heart.

Only when she saw "Hai" on Sheng Yan's preference form did her hope shatter.

She'd have to go to the capital to study all alone.

But it was also fine—there were Auntie Lu and Auntie Fu in the capital, along with their daughter Lu Miaomiao who was in middle school.

But unexpectedly, when the acceptance letters arrived home later, Sheng Yan's school turned out to be Capital University.

Only two streets away from Shen Xuan's Capital Media University.

Sheng Yan silently put away the acceptance letter.

Shen Xuan happily ate an extra half bowl of rice that day.

Later someone asked Sheng Yan why she went to university in the capital.

Sheng Yan thought for a moment, "Zhaozhao and Mumu were meant to be together anyway."

And now, during their freshman year vacation, they'd taken an overnight flight back, only to be met with a closed door.

...

When they asked the auntie where their two mothers had gone, before the auntie could speak, Sheng Yan's phone rang.

It was her younger cousin calling.

The cousin who was in high school said tearfully: "Sis, I've been abandoned!"

Sheng Yan: "?"

After asking, she found out that Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu, Shen Hui and Zhao Xuning, Gu Yixue and Shen Fenghe had all gone traveling.

And it was a group trip.

While Shen Siyan... that is, their young uncle, was in charge of watching over the company.

Sheng Yan silently lit a candle for their young uncle in her heart.

Chapter 195 - Part 2

Extra 17-2

Sheng Yan and Shen Xuan put down their luggage and went to find their younger cousin for a meal, the three gathering together.

They listened to their cousin complain about those two "unreliable" people.

"They're the real couple, I'm just an accident. A spontaneous trip without taking me is one thing, but they didn't even tell me. I only found out when I got home today that they took last night's flight to the seaside. I wanted to go too! Wuuu~!" The cousin said pitifully, then suddenly had a flash of inspiration and looked at Sheng Yan, "Sis, take me to visit your school."

"Don't you have classes?" Shen Xuan asked.

The cousin shook her head: "It's Saturday today."

Shen Xuan immediately became interested, elbowing Sheng Yan: "Quick, book tickets. Let's leave this afternoon."

Sheng Yan: "?"

"Split the cost." Sheng Yan said.

Shen Xuan froze.

Shen Xuan clicked her tongue, looking at the cold-faced Sheng Yan: "How can your 37-degree mouth say such cold words?"

The cousin immediately volunteered, "Sis, I have money, use mine."

As she spoke, she transferred ten thousand yuan to Sheng Yan.

Sheng Yan was shocked, "Where did you get so much money?"

Although the family was very wealthy, both Sheng Yan and Shen Xuan had been educated from childhood not to spend money carelessly, and not to think they were superior just because their family was rich.

This money was earned by their parents' generation and had little to do with them.

Even their usual allowance was based on the school's average amount.

But Sheng Yan studied well, and after finishing college entrance exams, before attending Capital University, the school gave her a one million yuan reward.

She deposited that million in her account, planning to use it as startup capital after graduation.

Plus, she normally didn't have strong material desires, so she could save most of the allowance her family gave her.

Shen Xuan was different.

Shen Xuan had no concept when buying things. She also didn't buy very expensive luxury items, didn't carry bags worth tens of thousands in high school—her backpack was just a very ordinary style that cost a few hundred yuan and could last several years.

But she liked buying miscellaneous little things.

After starting university, Xu Qingzhu gave each of them three thousand yuan in living expenses. Even in the capital with its high cost of living, this was enough to live comfortably.

Moreover, every week Lu Jiayi would take them out to eat.

When leaving, she'd treat them like children and slip them pocket money.

At first she'd slip them cards, but later finding they didn't use them, she started slipping them cash.

Giving them tens of thousands at a time.

Later Xu Qingzhu found out and had a very "serious" talk with Lu Jiayi.

After that, Lu Jiayi stopped giving them money and took them shopping instead.

The cousin was similar to them, also always having relatives slip her money or take her shopping.

When the cousin was young, her personality was somewhat introverted and she didn't like to talk much. When she went to kindergarten, she only played alone, so the adults felt sorry for her and were especially good to her.

But when she entered middle school, Shen Hui learned from Xu Qingzhu and began to control her spending.

However, the cousin's money was given weekly with free allocation.

Even if you spent all your money at the beginning of the week, Shen Hui wouldn't interfere, nor would she let others interfere.

At first, the cousin really had no concept of money and often overspent.

But after two weeks, she gradually started saving money.

However, in high school, the cousin's personality became more cheerful. After getting along well with her classmates, because she wasn't very good at refusing people, she would pay when going out, using up a lot of her savings.

And now she so generously said she still had ten thousand...

The cousin said sheepishly: "It was from my great-aunt."

Oh, given by Zhao Ying.

Everyone seemed to have a consensus—to make their own children frugal, but constantly slip money to other people's children.

Because Zhao Ying's child was in a similar situation, but Zhao Xuning and Liang Shi would occasionally slip the kid money.

Naturally, Sheng Yan didn't use her cousin's money.

However, when they went to the capital that afternoon, they discovered that Lu Jiayi and Fu You had also gone traveling.

Going with them were Zhao Ying and Yang Shuyan.

Sheng Yan & Shen Xuan: "..."

The twins said in unison: "Middle-aged escape?"

Chapter 195 - Part 3

Extra 17-3

Meanwhile, the beautiful women whom these kids dubbed the "middle-aged group" were driving wildly on the sunset boulevard.

The setting sun splashed across the ground, with lush green seedlings on both sides of the flat road. They drove with windows open, the free wind scattering their long hair.

Five cars, almost forming a convoy.

The suggestion for a group trip was proposed by Xu Qingzhu.

Over the years, she and Liang Shi had traveled together, and almost every winter and summer vacation they would bring their two children along, occasionally going out with Shen Hui's family or Shen Fenghe and her partner.

But trips belonging to just these friends were rare.

So she asked in the group chat: [Want to go traveling together?]

Everyone readily agreed.

Thus they embarked on a secret journey.

Without kids, wild and free, as if still in their youth.

Facts proved that this kind of travel made people young.

Going out with children, they were always worrying about the little ones.

Even though Sheng Yan and Shen Xuan were already so grown up, when they went out to eat together, if Liang Shi saw something on the corner of Shen Xuan's mouth, she would instinctively reach out to wipe it off.

This was being a mother.

Because in front of their own children, they would forever be mothers.

Forever putting them first.

But life was their own.

Traveling with so many friends was an exceptionally romantic thing.

They circled around the sea in Haizhou City's suburbs, then flew directly to northern Tibet.

After arriving in northern Tibet, they started renting cars for a road trip, went to see beautiful lakes, then rushed toward their evening rendezvous amid the sunset.

The panoramic sunroof opened, music playing from someone's car. The person in the passenger seat raised their arms, swaying along with the rhythm of the music.

Finally, they stopped near a guesthouse.

The guesthouse here was also full of Tibetan characteristics.

In early spring, the temperature difference between day and night here was large. Once evening came, it dropped below zero—extremely cold.

So everyone lit a bonfire in the courtyard, sitting together chatting. When they'd chatted enough, Xu Qingzhu called someone out, "Doctor Zhao, didn't you bring a guitar?"

"Doctor Zhao can play guitar?" Lu Jiayi asked in surprise.

Zhao Xuning: "...Doesn't seem like it?"

Lu Jiayi spoke honestly: "Indeed not."

This temperament was more suited to holding a scalpel.

But Shen Hui had already brought over Zhao Xuning's guitar.

Xu Qingzhu took out a rattle drum from the guesthouse room, while Liang Shi took out her harmonica. Zhao Ying clicked her tongue, "You guys are really competitive."

While speaking, not to be outdone, she also took out a thumb piano.

Yang Shuyan thought for a moment: "I'll just sing."

Gu Yixue: "Me too."

"What about you, big sister?" Liang Shi asked.

Shen Fenghe: "I won't..."

"She'll sing with me." Gu Yixue interrupted Shen Fenghe's words. Shen Fenghe paused, then changed her tune, "Mm, I'll go with Xiaoxue."

"You have to match everything?" Xu Qingzhu teased: "Afraid people won't know how close you two are?"

Shen Fenghe glanced at her: "Aren't you and my sister close?"

Xu Qingzhu leaned her head on Liang Shi's shoulder, "What do you think?"

"That's about enough." Fu You laughed, "As if anyone here doesn't have a wife?"

As Fu You spoke, she went to the car trunk and took out a bass guitar.

"Good heavens, are you planning to form a band?" Zhao Ying said.

Fu You curved her lips: "That's not impossible either."

She plucked a note first, then as the rhythm of the first line started, Zhao Xuning joined in, followed by Liang Shi's harmonica blending in.

A medley of various instruments.

Yet it sounded especially pleasant.

Most importantly, it had the sound of youth and freedom.

The bonfire illuminated their radiant faces, each wearing a smile.

Some people are forever young.

Forever brilliant and dazzling.